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‘Communism is no shield against imperialism’

Sardar Patel and Jawaharlal Nehru spar over China and Indian foreign policy



THE CATASTROPHIC MILITARY disaster of 1962 – when Chinese forces overwhelmed the ill-equipped and ill-prepared Indian Army in the Himalaya and nearly swept down to the plains of Assam – has loomed large over the public imagination in India, its ghosts resurrected whenever a crisis erupts on the frigid heights of India’s northern frontier. Coming after a decade where the defining objective of Indian foreign policy was friendship with China – immortalized in the oft-quoted slogan ‘Hindi Chini Bhai Bhai’[1] – the conflict has also cast a long shadow over the legacy of Jawaharlal Nehru, the man who presided over India’s foreign and defence policies throughout the 1950s and had been the architect of the country’s policy vis-à-vis China.

In the words of his critic and parliamentary colleague H.V. Kamath, the debacle not only ‘shattered Nehru physically and weakened him mentally but, what was more galling to him, eroded his prestige in Asia and the world, dealt a crippling blow to his visions of leadership of the newly emancipated nations’.[2] It was a blow from which he never recovered. Accused of cravenness, vanity and negligence, his foreign policy in a shambles, his illusions of ‘Asianism’ shattered, his self-appointed mantle of